Music licensing explained: a practical UK guide for cre8

Prepared: 11 November 2026
Audience: founders, creators and product contributors; no legal background assumed
Status: educational planning guide, not legal advice or a ready-to-sign licence
Next step: use the UK legal checklist with a music solicitor.

The short version

A licence is **permission to do particular things with someone else's work**. It is not necessarily ownership, and one permission does not automatically include every other use.

For cre8, keep three separate questions:

1. **Can this creator authorize cre8 to host and deliver the music?**
2. **What can this listener or buyer do with the music after receiving it?**
3. **Does cre8 have any additional publishing/collective licensing obligations?**

An account, payment, A-List badge or working download button answers none of these by itself.

1. One track can have several owners

Think of a song as both a recipe and a particular recording of that recipe.

Right	Plain-English meaning	Who might control it
Composition/publishing	The underlying music and lyrics: the "recipe"	Writers, co-writers, publishers; licensing bodies may administer particular rights
Master/sound recording	The particular recorded performance	Producer, artist, label or another recording owner
Performers' rights	Separate rights associated with recorded performances	Singers, musicians and other performers, subject to their agreements
Other incorporated material	Samples, artwork, photographs or other borrowed work	The relevant third-party owners

Example: a producer records a track with a vocalist, uses a sample and signs the master to a label. Uploading the producer's own WAV is not enough evidence: the label, composition owners, sample owners and performer arrangements may all matter. Permission must cover the intended uses, not just possession of the file.

UK copyright generally arises automatically. Buying a copy or receiving a file does not transfer its copyright. An assignment transfers ownership; a licence permits uses while ownership can remain with the creator [1].

2. What cre8 needs permission to do

The creator-to-platform licence should cover the real service, in understandable terms reviewed by a solicitor:

cre8 activity	Permission to address
Accept an upload and keep backups	Store and reproduce the work for the service
Transcode audio or generate previews	Make the relevant processed copies
Let members select and stream tracks	Make music available/communicate it under the agreed conditions
Offer a file or pack ZIP	Make and distribute permitted downloadable copies
Show artwork and release descriptions	Display the relevant image/text material

cre8 activity	Permission to address
Use a host, CDN or processing provider	Permit necessary service-provider handling, appropriately limited
Promote a release in an advert	Obtain the separate promotional uses required; do not assume normal hosting covers them

State the territory, duration, permitted audiences and what happens on withdrawal. A non-exclusive, purpose-limited platform licence is the suggested starting point: cre8 should not need ownership of an artist's catalogue just to host it. This is a drafting objective, not contractual wording.

There are two permission checks: the copyright/licence must allow the use, and cre8's audience/grant rules must allow this particular member to access it. A valid copyright licence does not mean every member is entitled to every file.

3. What the listener or buyer is allowed to do

A Dub Pack

A licence might permit personal listening and an authorized download. That does not automatically permit sampling, uploading elsewhere, public performance, broadcasting, commercial release or resale.

If a creator wants to permit DJ use, define what that means. A permission to download a dub is not a universal licence for every venue, livestream or DJ mix. The DJ, venue, broadcaster or platform may have separate rights obligations.

A Sample Pack

A buyer usually wants permission to incorporate sounds into new productions. The licence must explain whether commercial releases are allowed, whether attribution is needed, and what restrictions remain.

One possible product policy is:

> Permit incorporation into new musical productions, including commercial releases, but prohibit redistribution or resale of the standalone samples.

That is an **illustration to discuss with a solicitor**, not a complete licence or a permission automatically granted by cre8 today.

Also decide: permitted users/seats, territory/duration, collaboration, transfer, Content ID registration, attribution, AI-training use and any unusual limits. Avoid vague claims such as "full rights included".

Important: a sample-library licence allowing use in a finished track often does not allow extracting and reselling the same sounds in another Sample Pack. Read the source licence before accepting or selling that pack.

4. What common licence words actually mean

Term	Meaning to check, not assume
Royalty-free	Specified uses do not incur the additional royalties described by that licence; not copyright-free or universally cleared
Non-exclusive	Other people can receive similar permissions
Exclusive	Particular rights are reserved to someone; identify exactly which rights, territory and period, and check existing grants
Commercial use	Some money-making uses are allowed; the definition and exclusions still matter
Attribution	Credit must be given in the agreed way
Perpetual	A duration term; check termination conditions and whether the grant can validly cover that period
Worldwide	Geographic scope, not a guarantee that every necessary right is owned
Synchronization	Use of music with visual content, such as a video; do not assume an audio-only licence covers it
Mechanical rights	Reproduction rights in the musical work, rather than ownership of the master

Free content can still have restrictive terms. Paid content can still have restrictions. A licence cannot validly grant rights the licensor does not control. Do not silently relicense an entire creator catalogue under one site-wide label.

5. Where PRS, MCPS and PPL fit

PRS for Music / MCPS: relevant composition/publishing and reproduction permissions may be administered collectively. Explain cre8's complete service to PRS and obtain a written assessment of repertoire, territories, uses, reporting and fees. A direct artist agreement may not cover rights already assigned to publishers or administered under other agreements [2].

PPL: handles particular recorded-music licensing activities, but it does not offer a blanket solution for everything cre8 does. Its online guidance directs user-upload services and services offering on-demand tracks/downloads to the recording rightsholders for direct licences [3].

TheMusicLicence: do not confuse a licence for playing music at a business premises with permission to run an on-demand upload/download platform.

Practical consequence: do not buy a small clip or radio licence and assume it covers full-track streaming, selectable playlists, downloads and Sample Pack resale. Get the correct scope confirmed. A 30-second clip is not automatically exempt; PPL's clip product has specific conditions.

No licence fee estimate is given here: written quotes and rights-clearance costs must be added to the business plan. Hosting costs do not include music royalties.

6. Five everyday examples

Situation	What to check/do
A creator uploads a wholly original track they wrote and recorded alone	Verify their ownership/control, any society/publisher/label commitments and the platform grant; "original" does not finish the enquiry
A producer uploads an unofficial remix of a well-known release	Require appropriate master/composition and adaptation clearances; do not treat credit or free distribution as permission
A producer uses a purchased royalty-free drum loop in a finished track	Check the library permits that release and platform delivery; retain the licence evidence
The same producer sells that loop unchanged in a Sample Pack	Do not assume it is allowed; redistribution of isolated sounds may be prohibited
An approved member shares a private pack with a friend	Both the licence and the platform's explicit recipient access must allow it; A-List approval does not grant onward-sharing rights

These are screening examples, not definitive legal rulings on individual works. If rights are uncertain, pause the affected upload/sale and investigate.

7. The evidence to keep

For each release/pack, record:

- Creator identity and relevant owner/licensor contacts.
- Writer/master/contributor details and any restrictions.
- Source sample licences, collaborator permissions and direct/collective grants relevant to the intended service; keep evidence, not just a checked box.
- The permitted uses, territories, audiences and duration.
- Licence version, acceptance timestamp and the agreed files/version.
- For paid packs, a purchase receipt and durable record of the accepted buyer licence and content manifest; do not depend on today's editable pack.

Retain only necessary personal information, restrict access to evidence and use a documented legal/tax/privacy retention policy. Sensitive agreements should not be public or committed to source control.

Editing matters: cre8 lets owners change pack details, type and membership. Changing an existing pack must not silently rewrite a buyer's past purchase or licence. Define whether updates are included and how removals, rights disputes, seller departure and valid purchased access are handled.

8. What the product should make clear

Suggested future UX, **not an implementation claim**:

1. Upload: ask who owns/controls the rights, flag third-party samples/remixes and explain the specific permission being granted to cre8.
2. Publish: show audience and licence separately; check missing rights information.
3. Pack page: display a concise licence summary with the full version available before download or purchase.
4. Checkout: identify seller/licensor and pack version, capture required contract choices and send the receipt/licence. Follow the separate consumer-law rules in the UK checklist.
5. Account/library: preserve evidence of valid purchases independently of Pro status and mutable owner grants.
6. Reporting: provide a visible rights-complaint route, review/escalation process and access/cache removal where necessary.

Current audience controls and a free-form licence field are helpful foundations, not proof that this rights/commerce workflow already exists.

9. Questions to take to a music solicitor and PRS

- Which rights must cre8 obtain for uploads, on-demand streams, previews, downloads, ZIPs and private sharing? Which can creators directly grant?
- What changes when a creator has a label, publisher, collecting-society membership, co-writers or sampled material?
- Does any proposed collective licence cover this specific service, repertoire, territories and volume? What reporting/minimum fees/royalties apply?
- What should our creator agreement and non-exclusive Sample Pack buyer licence say about commercial use, Content ID, updates and termination?
- Which rights remain after a creator removes a pack or a buyer receives a refund? Do not assume an already-downloaded file can technically be recalled.
- What claims/removal/appeal procedures and record retention are appropriate for cre8's actual role? What should happen to disputed purchased content?

Bottom line

Permission to host, permission to access and permission to reuse are different. Keep them separate in contracts, the UI and the database. Start with a curated, documented-rights catalogue and get the service-specific licensing position confirmed before treating either free distribution or paid packs as cleared.

Sources

Primary guidance checked 11 November 2026. This guide paraphrases sources and does not supply legal drafting or an opinion on any specific track.

1. GOV.UK: copyright licences, ownership transfers and performers' rights.
2. PRS for Music: digital platforms and streaming licensing.
3. PPL: online licence scope and uses requiring direct rightsholder permission.